

Readiness in Software Engineering

Introduction

This podcast was done on Software Engineering Radio and hosted by Brijesh Ammanath. It was protagonized by **Max Geurnsey III** and **Luniel de Beer**, co-authors of the book *Ready: Why Most Software Projects Fail and How to Fix It*.

Context

Previously, there were teams of engineers that could not deliver. Apart from the internal problems of it, the team did not understand what to do and did the opposite. Requirement were made in one line, and much information was considered “implied”, so the team members were confused.

Backlog grooming (in SCRUM) was not enough to fix that, because in practice, it was about refining what is done and estimating what has to be done. The meetings were very short (1-2 hours) for the engineers to completely understand each of the requirements individually and the scope of them. In a nutshell, developers spent more time discovering what the task is about than actually committing to the task.

The product owner needed a way to ensure that the team implemented the specifications accurately. Each individual specification needs a quantity and quality of time for it to be ready for implementation.

Key concepts

Readiness: is a state of a task that is sufficiently understood, decomposed and de-risked.

Definition of Done: Ensures quality at the end of the pipe. This is what most teams use to determine the end of the requirement implementation.

Definition of Ready (DoR): This is the idea that Guernsey and de Beer advocate for. A task should only enter development phase if it meets these specific criteria:

- Clarity: The business intent and "Definition of Success" are unambiguous. Do we actually know what “success” looks like?
- Decomposition: The task is small enough to be completed without being blocked by unknown sub-tasks. Do we have the tools, permissions, and knowledge to do this right now?
- Technical Prerequisites: Access, environments, and third-party dependencies are already secured. Is there actual room in the system to take this on?

Bibliography

SE Radio 701: Max Guernsey, III and Luniel de Beer on Readiness in Software Engineering – Software Engineering Radio. (s. f.). <https://se-radio.net/2025/12/se-radio-701-max-guernsey-iii-and-luniel-de-beer-on-on-readiness-in-software-engineering/>